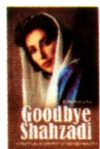


# Farewell to the Fearless

The personal resonates more than the political in this account of the extraordinary life of Pakistan's late political heiress



**GOODBYE SHAHZADI: A BIOGRAPHY OF BENAZIR BHUTTO**  
by SHYAM BHATIA  
Roli Books  
Price: Rs 295; Pages: 130

■ By Dilip Bobb

History is seldom kind to martyrs or assassinated leaders. Benazir Bhutto was both and is already a distant memory, even though her brutal assassination happened less than six months ago. London-based journalist Shyam Bhatia offers us a timely reminder of just how extraordinary a woman she was and, despite her privileged political lineage, the incredible odds she had to overcome to establish herself as a leader in the male and military-dominated feudal structure of Pakistan politics. As the first elected woman prime minister of an Islamic country, Benazir deserves her place in history and Bhatia had a front-row seat, quite literally, to her tumultuous life and times. He and Benazir shared a close friendship going back to their days in Oxford. Later, as a journalist in Britain, he kept in touch via a series of interviews in London and Dubai, where she spent her years of exile. In some, she made quite sensational revelations but asked him not to publish them till after her death.

Neither she, nor Bhatia, knew it would be so soon and so tragic.

The most sensational revelation concerns her personal role in exporting Pakistan's nuclear secrets to North Korea in exchange for Pyongyang's missile technology to combat India's programme. She refers to herself as "the Mother of the missile programme" and reveals that during an official visit to Pyongyang in 1993, she bought a long coat with deep pockets so she could carry CDs containing scientific data about uranium enrichment to hand over in exchange for similar data on missile technology which she brought back with her. She

also told Bhatia that she, as prime minister, under a secret deal with her Indian counterpart, Rajiv Gandhi, stopped Pakistan's support to Sikh extremists in Punjab. The quid pro quo was Rajiv's promise that he would pull Indian troops out of Siachen, a pledge he failed to keep.

She also claims that her father Zulfikar Ali Bhutto told her that Pakistan was in possession of a nuclear device back in 1977, much before 1998, when it was actually tested—probably, she reasons, a crude device acquired from China for a cold test. Once she became prime minister, however, she says she was denied information on sensitive security matters like the nuclear programme. She also reveals that General Musharraf had given her a Kargil-type plan to infiltrate an area such as Kargil to trigger a war and use it to seize Srinagar. She says she refused to go along.

## TRAGIC PRINCESS: Bhutto



Though this book was clearly hurriedly put together after her assassination, there are many insights into the Bhutto family, her relationship with her father and brothers, the estrangements and intrigues, her extrovert life in Oxford which included wine parties, sports cars and a string of British boyfriends, and her marriage and relationship with Asif Zardari. Indeed, it is the personal which resonates more than the political, mainly because of Bhatia's friendship with her, which became formal only towards the end, from Pinky and BB to Mohtarma and Shahzadi, the Princess. As this book shows, in many ways, her life was like that of a fairy tale princess, despite its tragic finale. ■

## NEW RELEASES



**THAKUR: A LIFE OF SRI RAMAKRISHNA**  
by RAJIV MEHROTRA  
Penguin  
Price: Rs 250  
Pages: 165

An intimate biography of the mystic who studied the appalling power that makes and unmakes the universe and attained, through spiritual realisation, *samadhi*, the state of consciousness that transcends the ego.



**RAGE RECONCILIATION AND SECURITY: MANAGING INDIA'S DIVERSITIES**  
by B.G. VERGESE  
Viking  
Price: Rs 495; Pages: 240

Seeking solutions to insurgency, Naxalism, tribal unrest and other challenges that India faces today, these essays debate issues of national interest like SEZs, the Mandal recommendations and the agrarian situation.



**TRACKING TIGERS IN RANTHAMBHORE**  
by GOBIND SAGAR BHARDWAJ  
Aureole Publishing  
Price: \$35  
Pages: 151

A wildlife tour of Rajasthan's most prominent national park and tiger reserve, with striking pictures and informative stories of the great cats sighted at play in their deciduous domain.